Another note on the simulation lemma

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1 Motivation for model-based learning

Consider the (discounted) infinite-horizon MDP setting $\mathcal{M} = (\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, P, r, \gamma)$. Assume that $\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}$ are finite, rewards are bounded in $[0, 1]$, the discount factor $\gamma \in [0, 1)$, and policies are stationary and stochastic. We have begun to see some online algorithms like TD learning methods, which learn value functions and policies in environments where the transition P and reward r are unknown. These algorithms are **model-free**, as they learn directly from experience rather than from an estimated model of the environment.

However, it is often desirable to take a **model-based** approach: we collect data (s, a, s') to compute an estimated transition $\widehat{P}$, which we can use to plan without further interaction with the environment. In chess, it is much easier to learn the rules and think ahead than to blindly learn from trial and error. In robotics, where data is expensive to collect, we would like to use offline methods like value iteration to plan for any number of policies and reward functions.

Of course, our learned model $\widehat{P}$ will generally not be perfect. Even small errors in predicting the next state can compound over time, leading to bad estimates of the value of a policy. We want some guarantee that if our simulated model $\widehat{P}$ is sufficiently close to the true model P, then the estimated value $\widehat{V}^\pi$ is close to the true value V^π. In particular, we want the optimal policy $\widehat{\pi}^\star$ in our model to be near-optimal in the real world. This is the guarantee of the *simulation lemma* [1, 3]. To simplify our analysis, we will assume that we know the true reward r.

2 State-action occupancy measures

For now, suppose we just have the true model P. As usual, given a policy π and an initial state s_0, we generate random trajectories $\tau = (s_0, a_0, s_1, a_1, \dots) \sim \rho^\pi_{s_0}$. Then, recall that the **step-h state-action occupancy measure** is defined by

$$\mathbb{P}^\pi_h(s, a|s_0) := \Pr_{\tau\sim\rho^\pi_{s_0}}(s_h = s, a_h = a).$$

In words, this is the probability that π reaches (s, a) from s_0 at time step h. This object is also commonly referred to as a **visitation distribution**, since it defines a distribution on $\mathcal{S} \times \mathcal{A}$.

It is also useful to take the *average* of the above probability over time, to get a sense of how long we spend at (s, a) throughout execution. By taking a discounted sum, we can define the **discounted state-action occupancy measure**, also a distribution on $\mathcal{S} \times \mathcal{A}$, by

$$d^\pi_{s_0}(s, a) := (1 - \gamma) \sum_{h=0}^{\infty} \gamma^h \, \mathbb{P}^\pi_h(s, a|s_0).$$

To motivate the discount, the γ^h factor serves both to discount the time spent at (s, a) far in the future and to ensure that this infinite sum converges, while the $(1 - \gamma)$ factor acts as a normalizing constant to ensure the distribution sums to 1. More mathematically, discounting the sum also gives us the following attractive property.

Lemma 1. Let $f : \mathcal{S} \times \mathcal{A} \to \mathbb{R}$ be any function. Then,

$$\frac{1}{1-\gamma} \, \mathbb{E}_{(s,a)\sim d^\pi_{s_0}}\big[f(s, a)\big] = \mathbb{E}_{\tau\sim\rho^\pi_{s_0}}\left[\sum_{h=0}^{\infty} \gamma^h f(s_h, a_h)\right].$$

Exercise. Prove the above property.

3 The simulation lemma

We can now state the simulation lemma formally. Consider two infinite-horizon MDPs

$$\mathcal{M} = (\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, P, r, \gamma), \qquad \widehat{\mathcal{M}} = (\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, \widehat{P}, r, \gamma),$$

where we think of $\widehat{P}$ as an estimate of P. (Note that the rewards are identical.) We will only write $d^\pi_{s_0}$ and $\rho^\pi_{s_0}$ in reference to the *true* model $\mathcal{M}$. Now, fix a policy π and initial state s_0, and let $V^\pi(s_0)$ and $\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0)$ be the exact value functions in the respective MDPs.

Theorem 2 (Simulation lemma)**.** The total value error is given by

$$\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0) = \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma} \, \mathbb{E}_{(s,a)\sim d^\pi_{s_0}}\Big[\mathbb{E}_{s'\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s,a)} \, \widehat{V}^\pi(s') - \mathbb{E}_{s'\sim P(\cdot|s,a)} \, \widehat{V}^\pi(s')\Big]. \tag{1}$$

In words, the bracketed term in (1) measures the difference in the one-step (estimated) value from (s, a), induced by the error in $\widehat{P}$. The simulation lemma states that the total error in $\widehat{V}$ is proportional to the average of this one-step error over the state-action pairs that π tends to visit in the true MDP. In particular, we do not need $\widehat{P}$ to be accurate in regions not covered by π. The simulation lemma also gives us a practical bound in terms of the L^1 error in $\widehat{P}$.

Corollary 3 (L^1 bound)**.** The total value error is bounded by

$$\left|\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0)\right| \le \frac{\gamma}{(1-\gamma)^2}\, \mathbb{E}_{(s,a)\sim d^\pi_{s_0}} \left\|\widehat{P}(\cdot|s,a) - P(\cdot|s,a)\right\|_1. \tag{2}$$

4 Proof of simulation lemma

First, we will prove the identity in (1). In fact, we will prove the trajectory form of this identity, and then translate it via Lemma 1. Expanding $\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0)$ and $V^\pi(s_0)$ using the Bellman consistency equations and canceling the one-step reward, we get

$$\begin{aligned}
\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0) &= \left(\mathbb{E}_{a_0\sim\pi(\cdot|s_0)}\left[r(s_0,a_0) + \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1)\right]\right) \\
&\quad - \left(\mathbb{E}_{a_0\sim\pi(\cdot|s_0)}\left[r(s_0,a_0) + \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, V^\pi(s_1)\right]\right) \\
&= \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{a_0\sim\pi(\cdot|s_0)}\left[\mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1) - \mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, V^\pi(s_1)\right].
\end{aligned}$$

Adding and subtracting $\mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1)$ (note the locations of the hats), we obtain

$$\begin{aligned}
\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0) &= \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{a_0\sim\pi(\cdot|s_0)}\Big[\mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1) - \mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1) \\
&\qquad + \mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1) - \mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, V^\pi(s_1)\Big] \\
&= \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{a_0\sim\pi(\cdot|s_0)}\left[\mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1) - \mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1)\right] \\
&\quad + \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{a_0\sim\pi(\cdot|s_0),\, s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\left[\widehat{V}^\pi(s_1) - V^\pi(s_1)\right].
\end{aligned}$$

Note that the blue term looks very similar to the RHS of our desired identity, while the yellow term looks like the expression we started with, i.e., the LHS of our desired identity. In particular, we think of the first term in the above as the step $h = 0$ component in our trajectory, corresponding to the transition from s_0 to s_1. To derive the rest of the terms, we can recursively expand the yellow term with the same one-step expansion. Concretely, observe that

$$\begin{aligned}
\widehat{V}^\pi(s_1) - V^\pi(s_1) &= \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{a_1\sim\pi(\cdot|s_1)}\left[\mathbb{E}_{s_2\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_1,a_1)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_2) - \mathbb{E}_{s_2\sim P(\cdot|s_1,a_1)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_2)\right] \\
&\quad + \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{a_1\sim\pi(\cdot|s_1),\, s_2\sim P(\cdot|s_1,a_1)}\left[\widehat{V}^\pi(s_2) - V^\pi(s_2)\right].
\end{aligned}$$

Plugging this back in, we get

$$\begin{aligned}
&\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0) \\
&\quad = \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{a_0\sim\pi(\cdot|s_0)}\Big[\mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1) - \mathbb{E}_{s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_1)\Big] \\
&\qquad + \gamma^2\, \mathbb{E}_{a_0\sim\pi(\cdot|s_0),\, s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0),\, a_1\sim\pi(\cdot|s_1)}\Big[\mathbb{E}_{s_2\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_1,a_1)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_2) - \mathbb{E}_{s_2\sim P(\cdot|s_1,a_1)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_2)\Big] \\
&\qquad\quad + \gamma^2\, \mathbb{E}_{a_0\sim\pi(\cdot|s_0),\, s_1\sim P(\cdot|s_0,a_0),\, a_1\sim\pi(\cdot|s_1),\, s_2\sim P(\cdot|s_1,a_1)}\Big[\widehat{V}^\pi(s_2) - V^\pi(s_2)\Big].
\end{aligned}$$

Now, we have *two* terms that look like the RHS of (1), corresponding to steps $h = 0$ and $h = 1$, and another term that looks like the LHS of (1), but now as an expectation over s_2. Each time we expand, we obtain a new blue term, one step further along the trajectory and with one more factor of γ, and another leftover yellow term at the next state. Unrolling H times in total,

$$\begin{aligned}
&\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0) \\
&\quad = \gamma \sum_{h=0}^{H-1} \mathbb{E}_{(a_0,s_1,a_1,\ldots,s_h,a_h)\sim\rho^\pi_{s_0}}\Big[\gamma^h\Big(\mathbb{E}_{s_{h+1}\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_h,a_h)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_{h+1}) - \mathbb{E}_{s_{h+1}\sim P(\cdot|s_h,a_h)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s_{h+1})\Big)\Big] \\
&\qquad + \gamma^H\, \mathbb{E}_{(a_0,s_1,a_1,\ldots,s_H)\sim\rho^\pi_{s_0}}\Big[\widehat{V}^\pi(s_H) - V^\pi(s_H)\Big].
\end{aligned}$$

For the purple term, the inner expectations depend only on (s_h, a_h), so we can rename s_{h+1} to s' and take the outer expectations over entire trajectories $\tau \sim \rho^\pi_{s_0}$. Moving the sum inside via linearity, and taking the green term over trajectories as well, we obtain

$$\begin{aligned}
&\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0) \\
&\quad = \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{\tau\sim\rho^\pi_{s_0}}\Big[\sum_{h=0}^{H-1} \gamma^h\Big(\mathbb{E}_{s'\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_h,a_h)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s') - \mathbb{E}_{s'\sim P(\cdot|s_h,a_h)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s')\Big)\Big] \\
&\qquad + \gamma^H\, \mathbb{E}_{\tau\sim\rho^\pi_{s_0}}\Big[\widehat{V}^\pi(s_H) - V^\pi(s_H)\Big].
\end{aligned}$$

Recall that value functions take values in $[0, 1/(1-\gamma)]$. As we take $H \to \infty$, the green term vanishes, since $\gamma^H \to 0$ and the expectation is bounded absolutely by $1/(1-\gamma)$. For the purple term, the h-th term of the sum is at most $\gamma^h/(1-\gamma)$ in absolute value, and so the series converges absolutely as $H \to \infty$. Thus, we obtain the trajectory form of the simulation lemma,

$$\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0) = \gamma\, \mathbb{E}_{\tau\sim\rho^\pi_{s_0}}\Big[\sum_{h=0}^{\infty} \gamma^h\Big(\mathbb{E}_{s'\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s_h,a_h)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s') - \mathbb{E}_{s'\sim P(\cdot|s_h,a_h)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s')\Big)\Big].$$

Applying Lemma 1, we get the equivalent occupancy measure form in (1),

$$\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0) = \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma}\, \mathbb{E}_{(s,a)\sim d^\pi_{s_0}}\Big[\mathbb{E}_{s'\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s,a)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s') - \mathbb{E}_{s'\sim P(\cdot|s,a)}\, \widehat{V}^\pi(s')\Big].$$

5 Proving the L^1 bound

It remains to prove our inequality in (2), which translates bounds on $\widehat{P} - P$ to bounds on $\widehat{V} - V$.

Lemma 4. Let $p, q : S \to [0,1]$ be discrete distributions, and let $f : S \to \mathbb{R}$ be bounded. Then,

$$\left|\mathbb{E}_{X\sim p}\, f(X) - \mathbb{E}_{X\sim q}\, f(X)\right| \le \sup_{x\in S}|f(x)| \cdot \|p - q\|_1.$$

Exercise. Prove the above property.

Now, we can prove our desired bound. Starting from the occupancy form in (1), taking the absolute value, and applying Jensen's inequality, we get

$$\begin{aligned}\left|\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0)\right| &= \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma}\left|\mathbb{E}_{(s,a)\sim d^\pi_{s_0}}\left[\mathbb{E}_{s'\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s,a)}\,\widehat{V}^\pi(s') - \mathbb{E}_{s'\sim P(\cdot|s,a)}\,\widehat{V}^\pi(s')\right]\right| \\ &\le \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma}\,\mathbb{E}_{(s,a)\sim d^\pi_{s_0}}\left|\mathbb{E}_{s'\sim\widehat{P}(\cdot|s,a)}\,\widehat{V}^\pi(s') - \mathbb{E}_{s'\sim P(\cdot|s,a)}\,\widehat{V}^\pi(s')\right|.\end{aligned}$$

Note that $\widehat{V}^\pi$ is a function of $\mathcal{S}$, and it is bounded by $1/(1-\gamma)$. Applying Lemma 4 for the distributions $\widehat{P}(\cdot|s,a)$ and $P(\cdot|s,a)$, we obtain the bound in (2),

$$\begin{aligned}\left|\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0)\right| &\le \frac{\gamma}{1-\gamma}\,\mathbb{E}_{(s,a)\sim d^\pi_{s_0}}\left[\sup_{s'\in\mathcal{S}}\left|\widehat{V}^\pi(s')\right| \cdot \left\|\widehat{P}(\cdot|s,a) - P(\cdot|s,a)\right\|_1\right] \\ &\le \frac{\gamma}{(1-\gamma)^2}\,\mathbb{E}_{(s,a)\sim d^\pi_{s_0}}\left\|\widehat{P}(\cdot|s,a) - P(\cdot|s,a)\right\|_1.\end{aligned}$$

6 Planning in the learned model

Finally, we return to our original motivation. Namely, we show that if $\widehat{P}$ is accurate, then planning in $\widehat{\mathcal{M}}$ gives us a good policy in $\mathcal{M}$. Let $\pi^\star$ and $\widehat{\pi}^\star$ be optimal in the respective MDPs.

Theorem 5 (Near-optimality of $\widehat{\pi}^\star$)**.** Suppose $\|\widehat{P}(\cdot|s,a) - P(\cdot|s,a)\|_1 \le \epsilon$ for all (s,a). Then,

$$V^{\pi^\star}(s_0) - V^{\widehat{\pi}^\star}(s_0) \le \frac{2\gamma\epsilon}{(1-\gamma)^2}, \quad \text{for all } s_0.$$

Proof. Decompose the LHS as

$$V^{\pi^\star}(s_0) - V^{\widehat{\pi}^\star}(s_0) = \left(V^{\pi^\star}(s_0) - \widehat{V}^{\pi^\star}(s_0)\right) + \left(\widehat{V}^{\pi^\star}(s_0) - \widehat{V}^{\widehat{\pi}^\star}(s_0)\right) + \left(\widehat{V}^{\widehat{\pi}^\star}(s_0) - V^{\widehat{\pi}^\star}(s_0)\right).$$

By the assumption and (2), we know that $\left|\widehat{V}^\pi(s_0) - V^\pi(s_0)\right| \le \gamma\epsilon/(1-\gamma)^2$ for every policy π, which bounds the first and third terms. The second term is at most 0, since $\widehat{\pi}^\star$ is optimal in $\widehat{\mathcal{M}}$.

Here, we required $\widehat{P}$ to be accurate at *every* (s,a), rather than on average under one occupancy measure. This is because we applied the simulation lemma to two different policies $\pi^\star$ and $\widehat{\pi}^\star$, and we do not know which state-action pairs they visit.

References

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